FARIA · 7 NOVEMBER 2026 · A LESSON FOR JEFF FRANZEN

Ships of exploration: four craft, four different jobs

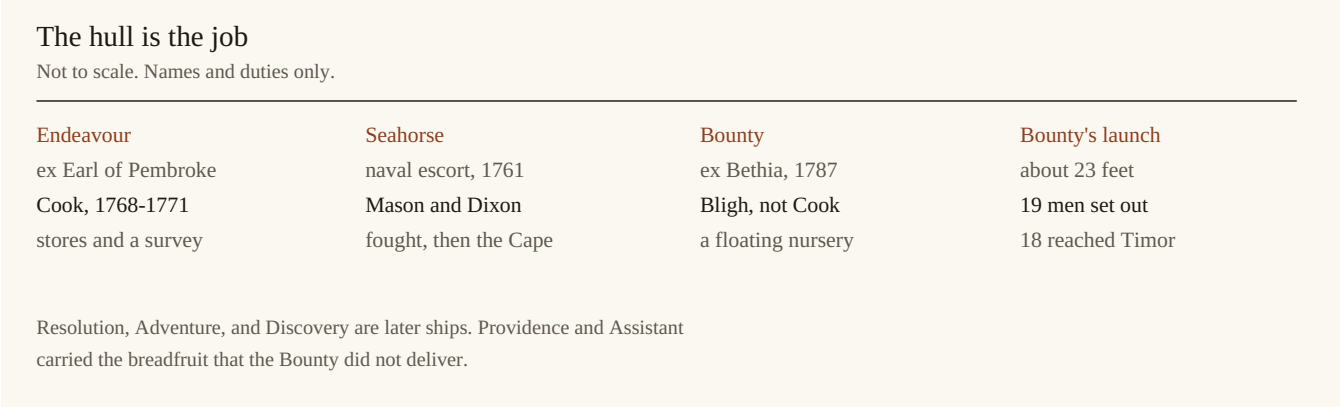
A ship's name is a job description if you let it be. Four vessels from this day's stories are easy to tangle, and they should stay apart.

Endeavour had been the collier Earl of Pembroke. The Navy bought a cargo ship because Cook knew that kind of hull and because a survey voyage needs room for stores, not a frigate's gun deck. She carried the first voyage, 1768 to 1771: Tahiti, New Zealand, the Australian east coast. Resolution, Adventure, and Discovery came later, for the second and third voyages. They are not nicknames for Endeavour.

Seahorse, in 1761, was the naval ship that took Charles Mason and Jeremiah Dixon toward Sumatra. In January she fought a French frigate. Eleven men were killed and thirty-seven wounded, by Mason's letter. The transit party went on to the Cape. Seahorse did not draw the American boundary, and she had nothing to do with the Bounty.

Bounty had been the merchant Bethia. The Navy took her up in 1787 and rebuilt her to carry living breadfruit, a nursery where a great cabin had been. William Bligh commanded. Cook had been dead for eight years. Joseph Banks organized the plan and stayed in England. Bounty is a breadfruit ship that became a mutiny. She is not Cook's surveyor.

Her launch was a working boat about 23 feet long, carried on board like any ship's boat. After the mutiny, nineteen men were in it. At Tofua, John Norton was killed. The remaining eighteen reached Timor. The distance usually given is about 3,618 nautical miles, not statute miles. How you count the days depends on which day's entry you start from, so this page will not pretend one duration is the only honest one. A later pair, Providence and Assistant, in 1791 to 1793, did deliver breadfruit. The boat's story is the mutiny lesson. The plant's story is the breadfruit lesson. Cook's collier is the Cook lesson.



Four vessels and the job each one actually did

Roles, not a scale model. Drawn for this lesson.

The illustrated lesson is download the PDF.

Sources

- Royal Museums Greenwich, Cook timeline: https://www.rmg.co.uk/stories/maritime-history/captain-james-cook-timeline
- Royal Museums Greenwich, mutiny on the Bounty: https://www.rmg.co.uk/stories/maritime-history/mutiny-on-bounty
- Royal Museums Greenwich, William Bligh: https://www.rmg.co.uk/stories/maritime-history/william-bligh
- Royal Museums Greenwich, the Bounty launch model: https://www.rmg.co.uk/collections/objects/rmgc-object-68956

Key facts

- Endeavour, ex Earl of Pembroke, was Cook's first-voyage collier. Later voyages used other ships.
- Seahorse carried Mason and Dixon in 1761 and was attacked. She is not the boundary survey and not the Bounty.
- Bounty, ex Bethia, was fitted in 1787 as a breadfruit nursery under Bligh, not under Cook or Banks.
- The launch of about 23 feet took 19 men. After Norton's death at Tofua, 18 reached Timor, some 3,618 nautical miles, not statute miles.